

EUROPE'S SOFT UNDERBELLY, IRELAND'S OPEN FLANKS

Performative Neutrality

Exam Number: 1

**Submitted in partial fulfilment of the requirements for the
Master of Arts in Leadership, Management and Defence
Studies**

Maynooth University

2026

**Supervisors: Doctor Rory Finegan and Commandant Kenneth
O'Rourke**

Contents

Introduction	1
Structural Vulnerabilities	6
Mitigating Factors and Sources of Resilience	11
Strategic Implications and Policy Choices	16
Conclusion	21
Annex	23
Reference List	32
Glossary of Terms	52
List of Acronyms	55
Index	58

Word count

$894 + 1186 + 1070 + 1250 + 599 = 4999$ words.

Assigned Research Question

In the absence of a comprehensive national defence strategy, evaluate how deficiencies in Ireland's maritime and air security posture create shared vulnerabilities for Ireland and the EU.

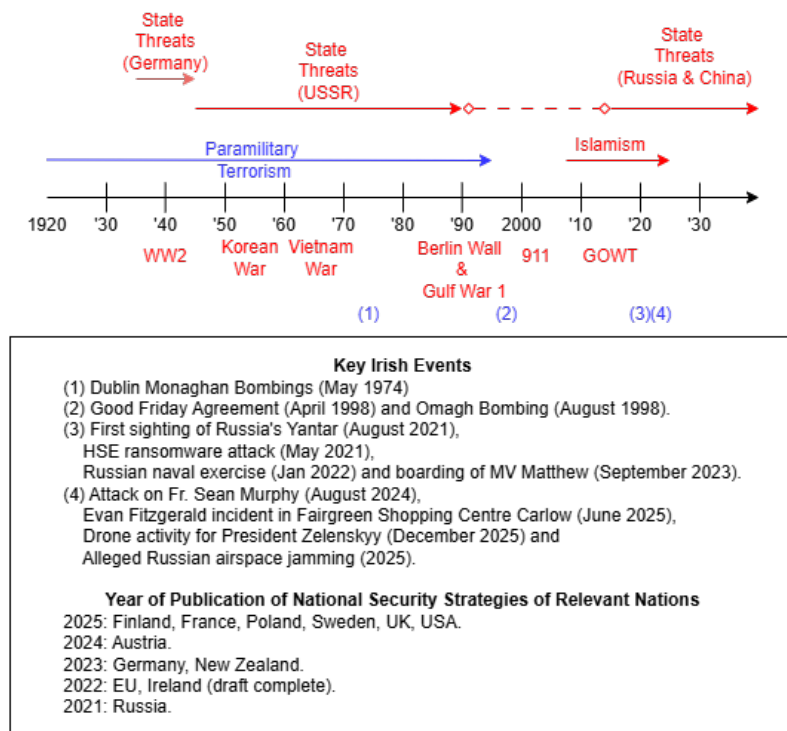
Disclaimer

Ireland's Maritime Security Strategy (expected December 2025) publishes after this essay is written.

Introduction

Geopolitical Tension and Modern Threats

The late twentieth century saw a shift from Cold War bipolarity to an American-dominated unipolarity. Recent scholarship argues that major-power competition is again hardening into a more bipolar or multipolar order (Gray 2011, pp. 209–244)¹. This renewed strategic competition has prompted many states to reassess their national security strategies and to foreground the *grey zone* and Hoffman (2007)’s “hybrid warfare”².



Evolution of threat perceptions and selected Irish incidents, with publication years of relevant national security strategies (author's illustration)

Figure 1: National Security Strategy (NSS) Timeline³

¹For different treatments of the emerging order, see also Bessner and Guillhot (2015, pp. 94–97), Clark (2005, pp. 229–233), Cottey (2025, pp.133–161), Friedner Parrat (2024), Regan and Sari (2024, p. 2) and Sanaei (2024, pp. 133–153).

²Assessments note returning long-term strategic competition and Russian hybrid aggression (Government Offices of Sweden 2024; HM Government 2025; New Zealand Security Intelligence Service 2025; Office of the Director of National Intelligence 2025).

³Threats viewed as from a: Western perspective (Red) and Irish perspective (Blue) (Clark 2005, pp. 229–233).

On an offensive-realist view, Ireland operates within an anarchic order where states seek to maximise power (Mearsheimer 1994; Mearsheimer 2001, pp. 29–48). This context makes Ireland’s “open flank” both perceptual and geographic: institutional memory gaps and normative assumptions obscure vulnerability. Despite a public consultation in 2019, and subsequent drafting, no NSS has been released (Department of the Taoiseach 2019)⁴. Figure 1 contrasts evolving threats, Irish incidents and partner NSS dates, underscoring Ireland’s shared risks without strategy. In the absence of an Irish statement of record⁵, this essay draws on the threat assessments of comparable and partner nations — such as Government Offices of Sweden (2024) — as a proxy for the wider strategic environment in which Ireland must operate. This matters for Ireland: peers have already reframed threats around hybrid pressure on critical infrastructure.

These partner assessments converge on a similar picture: a return to long-term strategic competition; persistent Russian aggression and coercive activity; growing use of covert and deceptive methods to influence decisions and gain access to technology and information⁶. They repeatedly identify Russia as the most acute threat in the Euro-Atlantic area. Its grey zone tactics borrow from and weaponise the other stated threats of: violent extremism, terrorism and organised-crime. They create overlapping pressures on democratic institutions. Against this backdrop, Europe’s “soft underbelly” and Ireland’s open flank must be understood.

In Putin (2007)’s ‘Munich speech’⁷ he quoted President Roosevelt that, “when peace has been broken anywhere, the peace of all countries everywhere is in danger”. Read in hindsight, the line sits uneasily with Russia’s subsequent uses of force. From a Western liberal perspective this appears straightforwardly hypocritical. From a Kremlin perspective, however, Munich can be presented as vindicated proof that Russia had long warned of a destabilising unipolar order. It presents later wars as defensive moves which were

⁴A draft NSS was prepared by the National Security Assessment Centre (NSAC) during 2020–2021.

⁵Ireland has published a National Space Policy (for enterprise) and a National Cyber Security Strategy.

⁶See also the treatments of strategic competition, Russian activity and hybrid threats in: Europol (2025), Government Offices of Sweden (2024), HM Government (2025), New Zealand Security Intelligence Service (2025), and Office of the Director of National Intelligence (2025).

⁷Signaling rejection of a subordinate Russian role and foreshadowing its assertiveness.

required to restore balance rather than as unilateral aggression⁸. This consistency underpins Russia’s contemporary “strategic deterrence” narrative. Grey zone activities, such as Russian Shadow Fleet (RSF) transits or cable-mapping⁹ surveys are cast as reactive responses¹⁰ rather than proactive probes (Adamsky 2025). Moscow can frame its actions as stabilising, even when those actions undermine security and test thresholds within Europe. This is consistent with Mearsheimer (2014)’s argument that Russia’s moves were reactive.

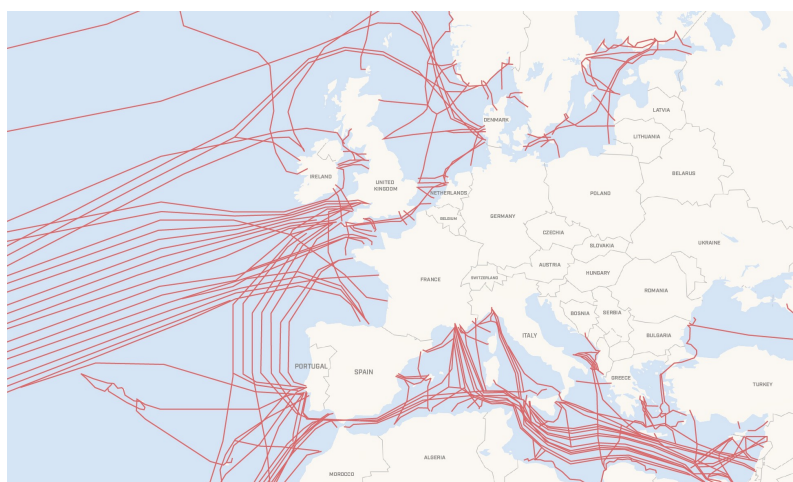


Figure 2: Submarine Cables (Jones 2025)

For Ireland, Russia’s maritime and aviation threat lies less in invasion than in ‘active measures’: submarine sabotage, pollution, jamming and coercive probing.

Article 29.4.9 of 1937’s *Bunreacht na hÉireann* requires a referendum to enter into common defence arrangements¹¹. Ireland is therefore constitutionally locked-out of the Treaty of the European Union (TEU)’s Article 42.2 (common defence) while taking a cautious view on Article 42.7 (mutual assistance). Neutrality itself remains a matter of Government policy rather than constitutional obligation, whereby foreign and security policy is primarily the prerogative of the Executive.

⁸Reiterated in later statements, including Putin (2022) and Putin (2024).

⁹“Cable” encompasses submarine fibre-optic cables, electricity cables and gas pipes.

¹⁰To Western “hyper use of force — military force” (Putin 2007).

¹¹See Annex, *Irish Neutrality*, for a fuller treatment.

Thesis Statement

This essay argues that Ireland's limited military readiness and persistent security gaps constitute a strategic vulnerability for European security amid great-power competition. Weak preparedness creates conditions which lower grey zone costs, enabling rather than causing them. The risk is acute during Ireland's EU Presidency in 2026.

Ireland's model of military neutrality compounds the problem. Defence spending remains low and capabilities underdeveloped¹². Ambiguities in Article 42.7 of the TEU further blur the boundaries of mutual support. Key questions remain unresolved. What counts as "armed aggression"? What assistance would partners actually provide? How do neutral states like Ireland fit within this framework?

This realist uncertainty invites hybrid exploitation, shifting burdens asymmetrically onto allies. Ireland gains politically and economically from the EU but invests little in collective resilience.

Methodology

This essay adopts a structured-focused comparison (George and Bennett 2005) and an author-devised three-pillar framework to evaluate Ireland's maritime and air security deficiencies.

Sources combine official records and peer-reviewed contemporary literature to balance academic rigour with policy salience. Scope is delimited to contemporary Europe, EU/NATO frameworks and Russia. It excludes cyberspace — a substantial separate topic.

The framework may overstate coherence in state behaviour. Irish sources dominate, reflecting the research question and author positionality within the Army. These constraints are mitigated through counterfactual testing and realist stress-testing in the analysis.

¹²See Annex, *Renewed Defence Concerns and EU Presidency 2026*, for details.

The Three-Pillar Framework

This essay structures the analysis around three pillars. First, *posture* examines *performative neutrality* and reforms shaping perceptions and vulnerabilities. Second, *preparedness* tests legal, organisational and capability readiness for grey zone threats. Third, *partnerships* evaluates EU/NATO ties, critiquing free-riding while identifying reciprocity.

The framework is critical, tests supporting and opposing evidence, anchors the hypothesis in Ireland's context and ensures continuity across the essay's sections. It is first deployed in support of the hypothesis, then to test counterarguments and finally to synthesise resolutions. As an author-devised tool, it risks reductive categorisation and is therefore applied analytically to highlight tensions as well as reforms.

Summary

This section has situated Ireland's neutrality and low defence spending within a renewed era of great-power competition. The next section applies the three-pillar framework to assess how far Ireland's current choices expose it as Europe's "open" flank.

Structural Vulnerabilities

Unlike comparable neutral nations, Ireland does not possess a credible defence deterrent. Given its position outside the North Atlantic Treaty Organisation (NATO)’s Article 5 guarantee, having constitutionally blocked automatic moves to “common defence” and its cautious approach to Article 42.7 of the TEU, this is an unusual posture. This section explains why *prima facie* Ireland exposes Europe amid Russian hybrid activity below the ‘threshold’ of war.

Posture

Ireland’s defence posture leaves it exposed as Europe’s soft underbelly. Hybrid campaigns exploit structural gaps. Crises emerge without clear warning or linear escalation (Hoffman, Neumeyer, and Jensen 2024). Policy documents accept that the Defence Forces (DF) remain below their stated Level of Ambition (LOA), with no sovereign air-policing¹³ and subsea-awareness (Department of Defence and Defence Forces 2024).

Rhetoric about renewed action underplays Ireland’s habit of treating defence as a sunk cost and presenting itself as a security bystander. Yet it hosts critical economic and international infrastructure, per McCabe and Flynn (2024) and Cottey (2022). Larsson (2024) shows that more-alert European organisations were outpaced by Russia’s activities. While Dublin can plausibly point to having ‘turned the ship around’, until change has been implemented, it remains declaratory. The persistent gap between political promise and capability marks Ireland as a shared vulnerability. For Europe, this reinforces the perception that Ireland consumes security rather than provides it.

Partners see a state missing capability and security architecture such as a National Security Agency (NSA). The Maritime Domain Awareness (MDA) remains opaque. There is no land-based high-frequency radar coverage of the approaches, nor an integrated mix of sea buoys and persistent patrols to close those seams. Mismatching procurement and

¹³Non-transponding aircraft can be invisible to civil ATC, forcing partner shadowing and rapid airspace-deconfliction to mitigate collisions.

ambition results in persisting fragility (Council of the European Union 2022). To other capitals, this combination of missing sensors and absent architecture signals a gap to cover. It is evident in NATO's visibility in the Irish Exclusive Economic Zone (EEZ).

Grey zone campaigns rely on deniability and disinformation (Gunneriusson 2019)¹⁴. Scholars caution that states must balance transparency against propagandistic-looking attribution (Lemmon 2024). Ireland often resolves that tension through secrecy¹⁵, reflecting an under-legislated and rarely-acknowledged intelligence instrument. The 2022 naval-exercise episode, where DF footage was suppressed and fishermen framed as first responders, damaged trust. UK practice in publicly reporting offers a sharper model — illustrated recently by *Yantar*¹⁶ (UK Ministry of Defence 2025).

Secrecy and delayed attribution blunt deterrence and leave partners guessing. The rhetoric to capability gap makes Europe collectively exposed.

Preparedness

Assigning state security to An Garda Síochána (AGS) without an NSS creates ambiguity in the DF's grey zone contributions. Gerasimov (2013) noted that Russia seeks to blur the lines between war and peace — operating deliberately below the threshold. Other states bridge this conceptual blur through regularly-updated strategies. In Ireland, by contrast, it hardens into an organisational seam. Grey zone activity is treated as a matter of “state security” for legal purposes. Yet the sensors, presence and deterrent signalling needed to monitor and respond sit largely with Defence. That mismatch in ownership risks leaving maritime and airspace protection in a grey area¹⁷ of its own. Such unresolved seams invite hybrid probing against Europe, entrenching ambiguity over who owns the grey zone where Russia is most likely to test.

¹⁴Though hyperbolic, authors such as Bachmann, Putter, and Duczynski (2023) see disinformation as being as, “destructive as kinetic operations”.

¹⁵Ireland's secretive approach to Intelligence elucidates this observation. It's hesitant to even acknowledge the existence of intelligence structures. Public information arises through parliamentary questions, such as Dáil Éireann (1982), Dáil Éireann (2021), and Dáil Éireann (2022).

¹⁶Yantar is widely attributed to the Main Directorate for Deep Sea Research.

¹⁷This policing-led instinct roots in the Troubles, where the State framed responses primarily as criminal law and order matters. It is evidenced in this instance through the Maritime Security Act (2004). The legacy: a security culture viewing coercive threats through a criminality lens, perpetuating the defence-security gap and political reluctance for a defence-forward NSS.

Neutrality is understood as performative by the Kremlin (Robinson 2025). Russia views Ireland as an exploitable seam between the US and UK. It therefore probes to undermine public trust, fosters a feeling of an ‘active’ threat, creates strategic uncertainty and weakens partnerships within Europe. Hybrid attacks on Europe are likely to escalate to offset strategic failure (Dixon and Beznosiuk 2022). Effective deterrence demands persistence of sensors and partner coordination¹⁸. In that light, Ireland risks being read less as a neutral buffer and more as a permissive corridor between major powers.

The United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS) provides for broad rights of innocent passage and tightly framed pollution-enforcement powers. Hence, it is difficult to classify RSF tankers as engaging in “non-innocent” passage, even when they form part of a sanctions-evading fleet. In practice, Russian state and RSF vessels minimise exposure. They remain outside most European territorial seas and route along Ireland’s western approaches. Boarding and enforcement powers are therefore constrained. Ireland’s realistic contribution in this lane is to detect, monitor and share timely information on such traffic, rather than interdict. Failing to resource even that baseline leaves a gap the EU cannot easily backfill from afar.

As the MV *Matthew* case elucidated, Ireland’s legislative absence on ‘hot-pursuit’ was a significant weakness for countering sabotage and deniable reconnaissance. President von der Leyen notes that “Across our Union, undersea cables have been cut” (European Parliament 2025). In a suspected RSF sabotage within our contiguous zone, only recent (untested) case-law may permit boarding after a hot-pursuit. This makes Ireland an inviting venue for undersea sabotage; a key vulnerability for Europe. Partners would expect decisive action. While liberal-institutionalist EU integration may close deficits, absent attribution creates targetable seams.

Ireland lacks a mature national-security architecture. It is hampered by the absence of a dedicated NSA which limits information sharing with partners¹⁹. Grey zone activities are accelerating calls for intelligence structures that operate at the speed of relevance and

¹⁸Having only two C295 airframes in service provides a maximum availability circa eighty percent (R. O’Connor 2025).

¹⁹It has been reported that information-sharing workarounds are affected through diplomatic pouches, which are unsuitable for dynamic situations (Senior Irish Army Officer 2025).

risks leaving Ireland two steps behind (Ince 2025; Wilson 2025). Maritime governance structures show similar immaturity: the Maritime Area Regulatory Authority does not engage on security matters. Being the only EU country without a permanent Defence Minister impedes effective EU engagement, posing a liability before the Presidency.

In aggregate, with a coastline which others must watch, paired with intermittent surveillance leaves Ireland a weakly prepared seam on Europe's Atlantic flank.

Constitutional limits on defence partnerships

Alleged Royal Air Force (RAF) assistance in Irish airspace exposes how opaque and fragile Ireland's security partnerships are²⁰. Evidence is suggestive though unproven. In a case currently before the courts, Senator Craughwell claims the existence of a "secret deal with the RAF" for interdiction (Houses of the Oireachtas 2025d; Meenan 2025). Litigation exposes improvised guarantees rooted in the secrecy-prone culture critiqued earlier. Performative neutrality is the strategy used to sustain *de jure* non-alignment through *de facto* partner-reliance.

If the partnership exists, it is not codified in public doctrine or treaty form. Oversight today remains episodic and adversarial, emerging through parliamentary questions, foreign parliamentary statements and litigation rather than routine scrutiny. This encourages a secrecy default in intelligence and security policy and leaves formal partnership frameworks thin. It is at odds with peer nations' approaches, which broadly conform to what Janowitz (1960) terms the constabulary model: integrating the public into security debates. Brittle, discretionary co-operation exports Irish maritime-air risk to EU partners. For a recognised picture within the EU, Ireland creates structural blind spots.

Summary

This section has argued that Ireland's declaratory posture, thin preparedness and opaque defence partnerships combine to present a soft, awkwardly placed flank. This is compounded by Ireland's Article 42.7 caution, which leaves it open to isolation in the event of

²⁰See Annex, *Alleged Secret Deal with the RAF*, for a fuller treatment.

serious event — perhaps where erstwhile EU partners don't come to Ireland's aid. Yet this outcome is not inevitable. The next section tests how governance-first reform, credible LOA 2 military and a more EU-integrated posture could reinforce these pillars, without requiring NATO membership or LOA 3 transformation.

Mitigating Factors and Sources of Resilience

This section tests the ‘soft underbelly’ claim. It asks how Ireland’s posture, preparedness and partnerships can be read as proportionate, defensible choices for a neutral small state facing Russian below-threshold actions.

Posture

Fanning (2015) argues that neutrality stemmed from Taoiseach de Valera’s pragmatic hedging, rather than being a principled normative commitment. It remains judiciously controlled by the Executive and provides realist flexibility — a stance affirmed by Harris (2025b).

The DF’s Chief of Staff (COS) stated that they, “have the capabilities and assets to provide an effective and credible response when required” Mulcahy (2025). On a narrow reading of “response” as detection and monitoring, this view has force. The Air Corps’ C295 aircraft can detect²¹ and monitor activity within and beyond Ireland’s EEZ, cueing naval assets as required. This posture is legally consistent and arguably proportionate, but it still leaves allies carrying the escalatory burden.

Hence, Ireland’s maritime posture is broadly consistent with NATO practice. UNCLOS’ provisions mean that RSF tankers rarely meet the threshold for non-innocent passage. It sharply constrains boarding, which is effectively prohibited for state ships. Even navies with far greater capability rarely do more in peacetime than shadow and report. A hypothetical LOA 3 Irish navy would still operate under the same legal and political constraints. Per Table 3, existing resources detect and surveil slow and predictable targets. From this perspective, the COS’ remarks are defensible. While security commentators may wish for greater capacity, Ireland’s reactive surveillance posture can be presented as satisfactory. Russia’s grey zone tactics can be conflated with “full-spectrum” defence.

²¹Reported to be capable of radar detection to 300km and visual identification in excess of 5km (Gallagher 2024).

This is a role which the Commission on the Defence Forces (2022) judged Ireland neither postured nor equipped to fulfil. Hence, Ireland appears as a liberal state privileging surveillance-led security — not derelict. However, legal constraints alone cannot explain why partners still experience Ireland as a weak flank. The difference is persistence, not authority. Larger navies maintain presence, surge and attribute; Ireland’s gaps lower the costs of probing.

The emerging Maritime Security Strategy (MSS) points away from this perspective²². Officials signal a civil-led, whole-of-government approach and stronger MDA. If delivered, these reforms would narrow the charge of a permanent vulnerability, by hardening how Ireland watches and manages its approaches.

Author’s illustration of Irish response pattern to Russian activity in the Irish EEZ: 2021–25 (n=13 Incidents & 32 foreign Vessels)		
Threat category	Incidents	Primary Irish response
Warships + Naval vessels	13	C295 patrol + OPV
Intelligence surface vessels	5	C295 patrol + OPV
Commercial + suspected RSF	Hundreds	C295 patrol (intermittent)
Suspected submarine	1	NATO response

Figure 3: OPV escort appears confined to state vessels. Confer Figure 5.

Preparedness

Ireland’s preparedness looks less bleak when the grey zone is considered critically. Do-bias and Christensen (2022) argue that states can manage risk through clear thresholds, proportionality and integrated civil-military responses — rather than escalation. For Ireland’s neutral small state posture, this implies that well-designed LOA 2 capabilities, rehearsed procedures and credible governance can shape the adversary calculus, even without LOA 3 forces or treaty guarantees.

Stensrud and Østhagen (2024)’s analysis of the Svalbard archipelago reinforces this view. Consistent coastguard presence, fisheries inspections, legal signalling and renewed

²²See Annex, *Emerging Maritime Security Strategy*, for a fuller treatment.

attention to seabed infrastructure have maintained the status quo. Ireland requires equivalent persistent surveillance, rigorous exercise of maritime legal-authority and attribution.

Irish and EU reforms follow similar logic (Government of Ireland 2022)²³. Hence, Ireland’s current and planned actions support a more optimistic claim regarding cooperative security. An LOA 2 governance-first and EU-integrated preparedness could mitigate the “open flank”.

Taking announcements on defensive procurements at face value, Ireland is set to greatly expand its surveillance and information-sharing architecture. The ongoing procurement programme for Medium Altitude Long Endurance (MALE) drones would constitute a significant improvement in persistence. However, this optimism must be tempered by the historical gap between political signalling and timely delivery of resources, which has recently defined Irish defence procurement. Incremental as they are, such steps make it harder for adversaries to treat Ireland as an unmonitored back door. Nevertheless, meaningful kinetic deterrent capability is aspirational, ensuring that the burden remains disproportionately with the EU.

Partnerships

Defence Forces’ participation in the Common Information Sharing Environment (CISE)²⁴ will provide Ireland with a concrete partnership mechanism to share information with other EU states and strengthen the MDA (Houses of the Oireachtas 2025b). In parallel, Ireland engages with NATO on critical undersea infrastructure through: seminars (including a recent event co-hosted with Iceland); non-voting (observer) participation in an emerging NATO critical undersea network; involvement in an “interoperability advocacy group” alongside non-NATO states such as Austria and Switzerland. These largely practitioner-level ties nonetheless give Ireland practical channels to align standards and

²³For detail see, inter alia, Commission on the Defence Forces (2022), Council of the European Union (2022), Department of Defence and Defence Forces (2024), European Commission (2025), European Defence Agency (2020), European Union (2023), EU-NATO Task Force on the Resilience of Critical Infrastructure (2023), Government of Ireland (2022), Jones (2025), and Sari (2025), which collectively reorient Ireland and its partners towards maritime security, integrated monitoring, critical-infrastructure resilience and co-ordinated attribution.

²⁴Approved by the Tánaiste as an early action of the new maritime security strategy.

share information — without formal alliance commitments. This indicates that Ireland shall behave more like a partner, even while it remains formally outside mutual-defence guarantees. EU and NATO arrangements suggest a denser, more functional partnership architecture than the “open flank” label implies. This sets the context for the politically sensitive strand which follows: quiet RAF co-operation on air interdiction.

Realist Cooperation Behind Performative Neutrality

Ministers have consistently repudiated the existence of an agreement sanctioning UK kinetic action, asserting that all international security activity is conducted within legal frameworks. This official line sits uneasily beside external and domestic acknowledgments. The UK Armed Forces Minister Heapey stated that RAF jets, “have deployed into Irish airspace on occasion” (House of Commons 2022)²⁵. Documented RAF search and rescue operations and “co-operation and a pre-agreed understanding” for contingencies speak to a “good” relationship, where UK assets quietly backfill Irish capability gaps (Houses of the Oireachtas 2005).

Any reasonable reading of these strands indicates at least tacit, and likely structured, UK support for air interdiction in and around Irish airspace. De Valera’s wartime security relationship with Britain indicates a similar pattern: realist cooperation behind a public posture of performative neutrality.

Viewed through this realist lens, Ireland is less a vulnerability than a state practising the kind of quiet, deniable co-operation de Valera pioneered. Formalisation may help, at the cost of performative neutrality — and funding. On partnerships, this suggests against an inevitable open flank but an incongruously dependent one.

Summary

Ireland’s posture is defensible, its preparedness coherent at LOA 2 and its partnerships realist. Much deniable Russian grey zone activity is routed through poorly-trained local assets and unreliable criminal proxies. Such tactics are not decisive and are vulnerable

²⁵Deputy Haughey has repeatedly referred in the Dáil to a long-standing RAF arrangement — purportedly dating to 1952 and updated after 9/11 (Houses of the Oireachtas 2023; Houses of the Oireachtas 2024).

to police countermeasures — a point often overlooked by commentators. Taken together, these pillars temper the diagnosis of being vulnerable, by confirming Ireland is technically capable of effective maritime surveillance and information sharing. This suggests Ireland is strategically dependent rather than fatally vulnerable, but ultimately confirms a failure of political will. The next section shall synthesise these two competing analyses to establish the core strategic implications and policy choices for the state and the EU.

Strategic Implications and Policy Choices

This section examines Russian and Irish security thinking, the Irish system's responses to hybrid attacks and returns to the essay's hypothesis.

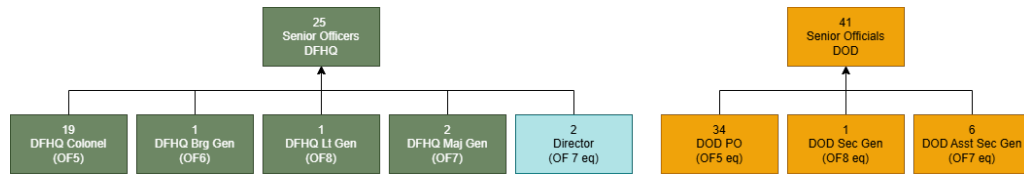
Memory

For Ireland, the task is less to denounce inconsistency than to understand Russian strategic culture. Mearsheimer (1990) warns that many Western publics now treat the post-1945 “long peace” as normal. They forget great-power competition and the resulting small-state instability. Russia's experience of revolution, invasion and repression has fed a durable sense of encirclement and vulnerability. It is often read as producing a siege-minded, zero-sum political outlook (Cottey 2025; Eken et al. 2025). Such asymmetric historical experiences shape how threats are perceived and narrated.

Ireland, with no living memory of conventional war and a liberal self-image, tends to read security issues normatively. Domestic debate sometimes mirrors this tension²⁶. These factors suggest that Ireland's reading of Russian activity is filtered more through domestic norms and politics than through an explicit, agreed threat frameworks (Adamsky 2025, p. 51). In the absence of a National Security Strategy, Ireland aspires to anticipate how Moscow might exploit perceived weaknesses. That disjuncture reinforces the underbelly problem: partners take Russian intent as a given and plan around it, while Ireland continues to vacillate. This memory gap helps explain why Ireland under-specifies the very threats which partners already treat as central to security.

²⁶Figures such as former MEPs Clare Daly and Mick Wallace have attracted criticism from peers and media for adopting positions seen as closely aligned with Russian narratives (Andrews 2024; Bielenberg 2022; O'Connell and Collins 2024; O'Leary 2024a; O'Leary 2024b; Pogatchnik 2024).

Department of Defence



Sources: Department of Defence (2025) and Defence Forces Ireland (2025)

Figure 4: DOD Leadership (author's illustration)

Turning from cultural memory to Irish institutions, analysing the Department of Public Expenditure and Reform (2022)'s Operational Capability Review (OCR) of the Department of Defence through Huntington's (1957) separation is illuminating. Of note, it criticises DF data analysis and sharing. Given the well-documented distrustful relationship, such findings risk justifying further centralisation rather than a shared data regime. The OCR also points to centralised decision making and, ironically, does not use the military leadership philosophy of mission command which it implicitly undermines.

At the same time, the review praises DOD's leaders while being silent on the civilian-heavy governance structure. Clark (2020)'s comparison shows a department significantly larger than peers, relative to force size — further elucidated through Figure 4. The more plausible synthesis is not benign understaffing, but a large talented department which centralises control, has a culture of distrust of its military and remains under-specialised in defence. This culture of mistrust originates in post-1924 mutiny legislation, granting sweeping authority²⁷ over the DF to a Secretary General, who can exercise authority in the Minister's name²⁸. Career security professionals are backbenchers — unlike the UK system Ireland otherwise emulates. The civil side lacks domain-specific security expertise. This can be extrapolated to the wider defence space and is highlighted through temporal indifference in defensive procurement. Hence, the State's repeated budget surpluses and persistent capability gaps read less as unavoidable austerity, than as a political choice to prioritise other areas over securing the conditions for its own prosperity.

²⁷Given that all spending above €10m requires DPER approval, DOD's true agency is debatable.

²⁸Through the Carltona principle.

DoD’s “reservoir of talent [...] is in a strong position” even as capability gaps widen. DPER’s 2023–2025 strategy focuses on fiscal prudence. Read alongside the severely critical findings of the CODF report on DF capability, a largely positive OCR for a department statutorily responsible for the, “raising, training, organisation, maintenance, equipment, management [...] and control” of the DF, is difficult to reconcile. The OCR validates financial stewardship over military effectiveness, making capability gaps a political choice that cements Ireland as an open flank.

Hybrid Attacks

The Russo–Ukrainian war and doubts about US guarantees have reshaped Europe’s security assumptions (Houses of the Oireachtas 2025a). Ireland’s thinking on Hybrid Attack remains opaque, exposing preparedness and partnership gaps. Partner analyses of critical infrastructure anticipate reversible, deniable Russian probes against cables, energy links and airspace to test allied cohesion. Despite addressing vulnerability critiques, Irish contingency planning remains vague. Phrases such as “vulnerabilities of our infrastructure” (Houses of the Oireachtas 2025b) capture a deeper reluctance to define aggression thresholds, attribution processes or how Article 42.7 assistance would operate²⁹. While the MSS promises a whole-of-government response, coordination rarely extends to tactical exercises. By keeping its red lines unspoken, Ireland relies on Europe’s strategic imagination, weakening deterrence and credibility.

The Dublin Airport drone incident exemplified these shortcomings. Planned air-defence capabilities face legal and procedural obstacles to use in civilian settings³⁰. Irish rules of engagement (COD-6) focus on defence of oneself and their post, leaving national-level responses unclear. Unlike French forces, which swiftly neutralised drones over a nuclear base (Franceinfo avec AFP 2025), Ireland lacks both counter-UAS systems and clear authority to employ them. Legislative ambiguity — especially between Garda-led security incidents and state defence — coupled with an absence of ex-ante ar-

²⁹See North Atlantic Treaty Organization (2024).

³⁰An initial capability is projected for 2028.

rangements, ensures any real-time response remains uncertain. Without an NSS, ambiguity signals vulnerability, not restraint.

Public reaction reinforced this dynamic. Media reports quoted “senior gardaí” criticising the Defence Forces’ response (Lally, Gallagher, and Paul 2025), yet the forces are legally barred from explaining operational limits. An entrenched culture of secrecy appears to favour blame-trading over accountability. Misconceptions about Defence Force authority — why they “didn’t shoot down the drones” — ignore absent capability, authorisation and rules of engagement. Persistent procurement delays compound the deficit. Legal opacity and bureaucratic caution ultimately sustain the perception of Ireland as a strategically exposed and institutionally constrained flank within European security.

The incident offered a vignette of Ireland’s immature approach to security. Media reports have mooted international assistance during the 2026 EU Presidency — constituting performative neutrality or a realist hedge. Others interpret Article 15.6.2 of the Constitution³¹ as prohibiting foreign forces from operating in Ireland. In an apparent act of realist contrivance, N. O’Connor (2025b) reported that foreign police units provided counter-drone effectors. Yet the Government’s non-disclosure until media reporting, lack of attribution³² and denial of any expectation of external security support for the Presidency (Cunningham 2025), exemplifies immaturity. It reflects an unwillingness to engage the public, per Janowitz (1960), and a preference for managed narratives over transparent strategic communication. Such institutional ambiguity in the grey zone directly undermines deterrence.

Synthesis

The Annex’s Figure 6 sets out a notional governance-first architecture for legislative and policy integration. The remaining question is how far that seam can be hardened in the coming decade. One plausible path is to treat dependence as explicit: publishing a credible

³¹“No military or armed force, other than a military or armed force raised and maintained by the Oireachtas, shall be raised or maintained for any purpose whatsoever”, (Government of Ireland 1937).

³²Despite widespread suspicion of Russian actors.

NSS and MSS, resourcing an effective MDA centre, considering an NSA³³, formalising quiet RAF arrangements and clarifying Article 42.7 assistance. Such steps must trade performative neutrality for meaningful funding. They would make hybrid attacks harder to stage and easier for partners to deter and respond.

Central Hypothesis and the Weak Flank

We return to the hypothesis. Read across the pillars and the preceding discussion, the essay advances a core proposition and the conditions under which it would be disproved.

Proposition. Ireland's current posture and capability gaps make it an open flank on Europe's edge and a plausible theatre for hybrid attacks, for example during its EU Presidency in 2026³⁴.

Falsifiers. Ireland leads the response to a major hybrid incident on its territory without significant reliance on partner assets, attribution mechanisms or legal cover; funded plans deliver credible detection and interdiction capability by 2030, closing the gap with peer small states.

Inference. On present evidence Ireland exhibits the predicted weak-flank pattern: structurally exposed but partially mitigated by emerging LOA 2 and EU-integrated reforms.

Policy Implications

In the next decade, the only realistic way to harden that flank is a governance-first, LOA 2, EU-integrated posture that makes dependence explicit and managed rather than tacit and brittle. It is incumbent upon Ireland to publish the NSS and MSS. The activation of an NSA would significantly enhance Ireland's interoperability — necessitating legislation to move past Ireland's secretive approach to security and defence.

³³To include a dedicated maritime security component to coordinate and deliver a whole-of-government response.

³⁴Dixon and Beznosiuk (2022) considers that strategic failure and absent European grey zone thresholds effectively *compel* Russia towards hybrid escalation; this resonates with suspected Russian involvement in the Dublin drone incidents (O'Keeffe 2025a) — while attribution remains unproven.

Conclusion

Taken together, the three pillars with the analysis of memory and departmental culture point towards a qualified but still uncomfortable judgement on how Irish deficiencies create shared vulnerabilities for the EU. Structurally, Ireland remains outside NATO's Article 5 guarantee, has locked itself constitutionally out of any automatic move to EU "common defence" (under Article 42.2), while treating mutual assistance (Article 42.7) cautiously. In practice, Ireland has opted out of hard guarantees, making only limited compensatory investments — consistent with a liberal-institutionalist security logic.

In that setting, Russia can plausibly read Ireland as a relatively low-risk theatre for grey zone activities, up to and including hybrid attack. These would seek to undermine public trust, foster a feeling of an 'active' threat, create strategic uncertainty and weaken partnerships within Europe. Within those limits, the DF stays below strength, the AGS–DF seam in the grey zone persists and a centralising, fiscally-conservative DOD slows adaptation. Rhetoric emphasises projected expenditure more than capability. The counter-argument showed that posture, preparedness and partnerships can be read more charitably as proportionate LOA 2 choices. Cyber policy is likely an exception where strategy and delivery align. That remains mitigation rather than cancellation: Ireland still presents as an ambiguously dependent flank on Europe's Atlantic edge.

The essay's analysis deepened this picture. It argued that Irish strategic memory and political culture tend to read Russian behaviour through a liberal, legalist lens. However, Moscow frames the same acts as reactionary defensive moves within a long struggle against perceived encirclement.

Without a published National Security Strategy, Ireland will struggle to decide what counts as armed aggression and to link legal thresholds to action. Should Article 42.7 support be sought, legal and other difficulties would arise (such as rules of engagement and status of forces agreements). An unusually powerful and civilian-heavy DOD has

Conclusion

normalised budgetary caution and centralised control, even as independent review bodies catalogue capability deficits in the forces it oversees.

The State is now recording repeated budget surpluses while core maritime and air gaps persist. That pattern reads less as unavoidable austerity than as a political choice to prioritise other areas over securing an Atlantic flank that underpins much of Ireland's prosperity. Even a sudden shift to LOA 3 spending would not deliver credible capability within this decade. The only realistic medium-term action for hardening the flank is governance-first reform, meaningful LOA 2 delivery and deepened partnerships.

The essay therefore concludes with a qualified verdict. Deficiencies in Ireland's maritime and air security posture do create shared vulnerabilities for Ireland and the European Union. These are not immutable and do not justify a defeatist reading.

It is incumbent upon Ireland to publish the NSS and MSS. A full-time Minister for Defence and activation of a National Security Agency would significantly enhance Ireland's interoperability with EU partners — necessitating legislation to move past Ireland's secretive approach to security and defence. Realist arrangements such as quiet RAF support may continue to be prudent policy. However, they are fundamentally incongruent with a meaningful liberal-institutionalist approach to building credibility with partners.

Such reforms would not create military power; they would formalise — and likely end — performative neutrality. They would not remove the structural facts of geography and small-state scale. They would, however, narrow the gap between promise and delivery, to align rhetoric more closely with capability. In doing so, they would make it harder for adversaries to stage hybrid attacks at Ireland's expense. It would be easier for partners to see Ireland not merely as Europe's soft underbelly, but as a small state taking its share of responsibility, for the security of the order on which it depends.

Annex

This annex presents the results of research, which are supplementary for the interested reader.

Renewed Defence Concerns and EU Presidency 2026

Recent analyses highlight growing concern over Ireland's defence posture, amplified by its 2026 EU Presidency. The Dublin 'drone incident' occurred while writing the essay and produced significant commentary. Hence, such analyses are noted: Cox (2025), Dunphy (2025), Fitzgerald (2025), King (2025), Lally, Gallagher, and Paul (2025), McDonnell (2025), N. O'Connor (2025a), The Irish Politics Newsletter (2025), The Sunday Times Ireland (2025a), The Sunday Times Ireland (2025b), Varadkar (2025), and Webber and Warrell (2025).

Irish Neutrality and Foreign Military Assistance

Hynes (2024) is recommended reading on Ireland’s neutrality.

TEU’s Article 42.2 states:

The common security and defence policy shall include the progressive framing of a common Union defence policy. This will lead to a common defence, when the European Council, acting unanimously, so decides. It shall in that case recommend to the Member States the adoption of such a decision in accordance with their respective constitutional requirements.

TEU’s Article 42.7 states:

If a Member State is the victim of armed aggression on its territory, the other Member States shall have towards it an obligation of aid and assistance by all the means in their power, in accordance with Article 51 of the United Nations Charter. This shall not prejudice the specific character of the security and defence policy of certain Member States.

Bunreacht na hÉireann, through Article 29.1, affirms Ireland’s commitment to peace and friendly co-operation among nations. Article 29.4.9 places a constitutional lock on joining any EU “common defence” — within the meaning of TEU’s Article 42.2 — without prior approval of the people in a referendum (European Union 2013; Government of Ireland 1937).

Government statements characterise Ireland’s policy of military neutrality as non-participation in military alliances or mutual defence arrangements (Leahy and Gallagher 2022). They make clear that there are no plans either to alter this policy or to enshrine neutrality in the Constitution. Ministers argue that such a referendum would unduly constrain the Executive’s authority over external relations under Article 29, even as they acknowledge that neutrality does not insulate Ireland from a more volatile European security environment (Houses of the Oireachtas 2025c). Furthermore “mutual assistance” through TEU’s Article 42.7 is treated cautiously by Government. The Minister for Defence has

stated that “for a country like Ireland, we have an obligation to look at how we can be of assistance, but we do not have an obligation to do anything that in any way undermines or contradicts our own policy on defence, which is one of neutrality” (Houses of the Oireachtas 2015).

Neutrality itself thus remains a matter of Government policy rather than constitutional obligation. This continues the pattern established under Taoiseach de Valera, whereby foreign and security policy is primarily the prerogative of the Executive (Ayiatis 2023; Fanning 2015; Hynes 2024).

Mutual assistance as required following “armed aggression” is reasonably expected to involve foreign military forces aiding the sovereign. Such presence is typically covered by a Status of Forces Agreement (SOFA). The Constitution’s Article 15.6.2 is therefore relevant to Ireland’s receipt of military assistance. It states that “no military or armed force, other than a military or armed force raised and maintained by the Oireachtas, shall be raised or maintained for any purpose whatsoever”. Interpretations of this exist (including within DOD) which understand this to mean that foreign forces cannot operate in Ireland legally.

Russian Maritime Activity in Ireland's EEZ

This section presents open source data used in the analysis of Irish maritime security posture in the main body. I reviewed primary and secondary reports of Russian naval, commercial and suspected RSF vessels transiting or operating within the Irish EEZ, together with documented Irish and allied responses. Where possible, sightings were cross-referenced with official releases from the Irish Defence Forces, NATO maritime commands and reputable public domain intelligence summaries.

The figure below plots these incidents over time. It groups vessels by type and aligns the recorded response with each event. The resulting evidentiary log is consistent with a pattern of C295-led surveillance across all categories. Irish offshore patrol vessels are deployed as an escalation measure for state-linked Russian warships and intelligence platforms.

Sources: Allison (2023), Donegal Live (2021), Fox (2025a), Fox (2025b), Fox and McDonald (2025), Gallagher (2022), Gallagher (2023), Gallagher (2025a), Gallagher (2025b), Gallagher (2025c), Gallagher (2025d), Gallagher (2025e), Houses of the Oireachtas (2025b), Hussey (2025), Mooney (2023), Mooney (2024), Murphy (2025), Defence Forces Officer (2025), Óglaigh na hÉireann (2022), Óglaigh na hÉireann (2023), O'Keeffe (2025b), and The Irish Insider (2025)

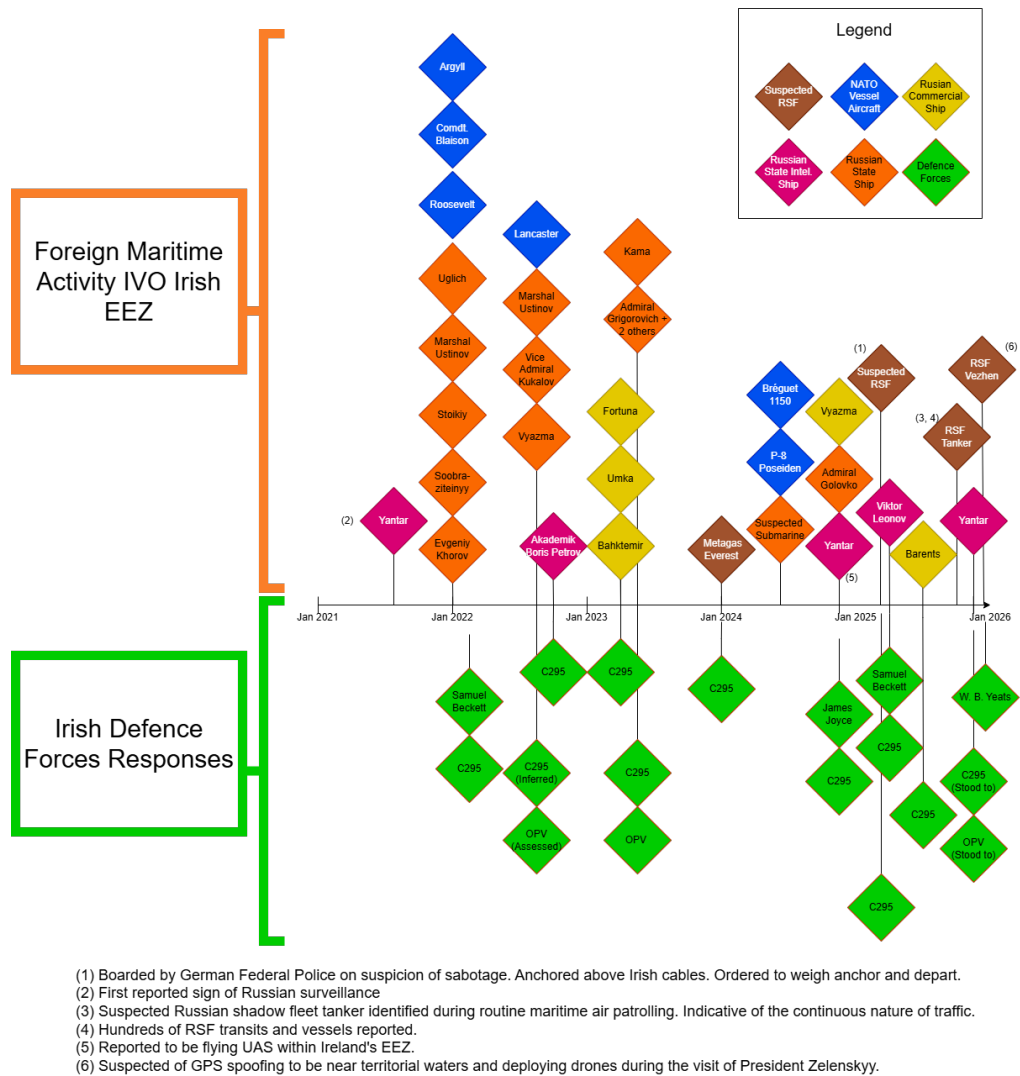


Figure 5: Evolution of Russian maritime activity in Irish EEZ (author's illustration)³⁵

Alleged Secret Deal with the RAF

The controversy over alleged RAF assistance in Irish airspace exposes how opaque and fragile Ireland’s security partnerships are. Ministers have repeatedly denied the existence of an agreement permitting lethal action, insisting that any international security co-operation is conducted in a lawful manner (Houses of the Oireachtas 2017; Houses of the Oireachtas 2022). This official line sits uneasily beside external and domestic acknowledgements. The UK Armed Forces Minister Heappey stated that RAF jets, “have deployed into Irish airspace on occasion” (House of Commons 2022). Senator Craughwell advances the opposite view, alleging a “secret deal with the RAF” for interdiction — in a case currently before the courts (Houses of the Oireachtas 2025d; Meenan 2025). Deputy Haughey has repeatedly referred in the Dáil to a long-standing RAF arrangement³⁶ (Houses of the Oireachtas 2023; Houses of the Oireachtas 2024). Documented RAF search and rescue operations — such as recorded by Minister Wilson (Houses of the Oireachtas 1991) — speak to an existing “good” cooperative relationship where UK assets quietly backfill Irish capability gaps. Taoiseach Ahern recorded “co-operation and a pre-agreed understanding” for hijack contingencies (Houses of the Oireachtas 2005).

³⁶Purportedly dating to 1952 and updated after 9/11.

Emerging Maritime Security Strategy

In order to elucidate ongoing planning, I interrogated testimony to the Joint Committee on Defence and National Security indicates and parliamentary debates (Harris 2025a; Houses of the Oireachtas 2021; Houses of the Oireachtas 2025b). The planned MSS is intended to move rapidly from public consultation in Q2 2025 to publication before year's end . Officials describe a whole-of-government approach with civil-led co-ordination, underpinned by a joint MDA and co-ordination centre. The Defence Forces are to participate in CISE, enabling structured information sharing with other EU maritime authorities. Ireland is to continue learning lessons from partner nations such as Estonia, Finland, France, the Netherlands, Norway and the UK. The strategy is also expected to continue to develop shared goals on maritime awareness and critical infrastructure protection through NATO Individual Tailored Partnership Programme (ITPP) and to maintain participation in EDA Project: Maritime Surveillance (MARSUR) — in order to promote information sharing among European Defence Agency (EDA) members. While the procurement of a multi-role vessel remains planned, it would be prudent to include an anti-submarine warfare capability and supplement with multi-role auxiliary vessels. Finally, this essay considers it as a logical extension that in future the DF seeks to exercise with the Joint Expeditionary Force (JEF) and deepen cooperation with member nations.

Proposed Governance Structures

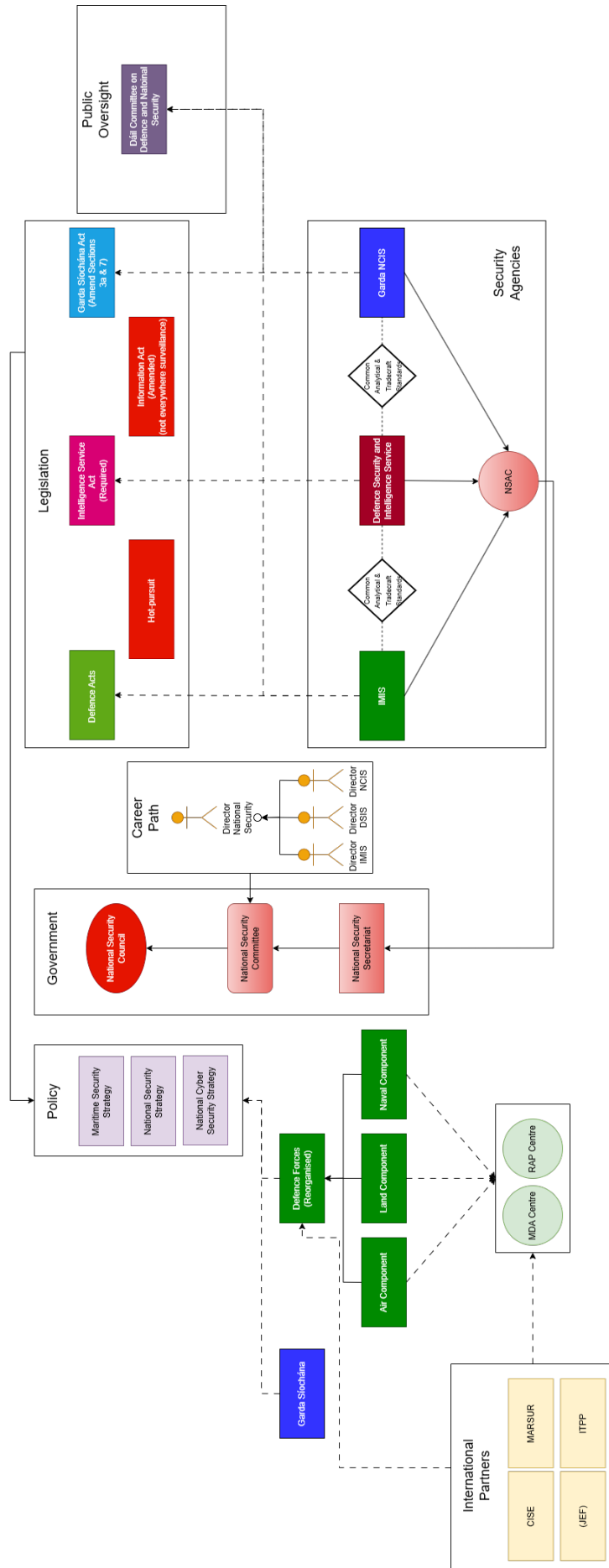


Figure 6: Proposed governance-first national security and maritime architecture for Ireland (author's illustration)

Reference List

- Adamsky, D. (2025). Quo vadis, Russian deterrence? Strategic culture and coercion innovations. *International Security*, 49 (3), pp. 50–83. DOI: 10.1162/isec_a_00502. [online]. Available at: URL: https://doi.org/10.1162/isec_a_00502 (accessed 29 November 2025).
- Allison, G. (January 24, 2023). *NATO maritime patrol aircraft monitoring waters near Ireland*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://ukdefencejournal.org.uk/nato-maritime-patrol-aircraft-monitoring-waters-near-ireland/> (accessed 29 November 2025).
- Andrews, B. (May 13, 2024). *Russian interference now a stark reality in Irish elections – MEP Andrews*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.fiannafail.ie/news/russian-interference-now-a-stark-reality-in-irish-elections-mep-andrews> (accessed 29 November 2025).
- Ayiotis, D. (2023). Joint Irish-British Military Planning and Operations: A Historical Perspective. *Defence Forces Review*.
- Bachmann, S. D., Putter, D., and Duczynski, G. (2023). Hybrid warfare and disinformation: a Ukraine war perspective. *Global Policy*, 14, pp. 858–869. DOI: 10.1111/1758-5899.13257. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/1758-5899.13257> (accessed 28 November 2025).
- Bessner, D. and Guilhot, N. (2015). How realism waltzed off: Liberalism and decision-making in Kenneth Waltz’s neorealism. *International Security*, 40 (2), pp. 87–118.
- Bielenberg, K. (February 4, 2022). *Big read: Mick Wallace and Clare Daly – the ‘anti-imperialists’ who defended Putin*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.independent.ie/irish-news/big-read-mick-wallace-and-clare-daly-the-anti-imperialists-who-defended-putin/41407535.html> (accessed 29 November 2025).

- Clark, B. (2020). An Examination of civilian governance of the armed forces in Ireland and other neutral EU States. *Defence Forces Review*.
- Clark, I. (2005). *Legitimacy in international society*. Oxford: Oxford University Press. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://doi.org/10.1093/0199281755.001.0001> (accessed 15 October 2025).
- Commission on the Defence Forces (2022). *Report of the Commission on the Defence Forces*.
- Cottey, A. (2022). A celtic zeitenwende? Continuity and change in irish national security policy. *Defence Forces Review*, 2022, pp. 1–10.
- (2025). *Security in the 21st Century Europe – third edition*. London: Bloomsbury Academic.
- Council of the European Union (March 21, 2022). *A strategic compass for security and defence: for a European Union that protects its citizens, values and interests and contributes to international peace and security*. Brussels: Council of the European Union.
- Cox, J. (December 4, 2025). *Ireland 'unprepared' for coastal threats but could avail of EU assistance, MEP says*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.breakingnews.ie/ireland/ireland-unprepared-for-coastal-threats-but-could-avail-of-eu-assistance-mep-says-1838022.html> (accessed 5 December 2025).
- Cunningham, P. (December 7, 2025). *No external security during EU presidency, says Lawless*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.rte.ie/news/politics/2025/1207/1547739-politics/> (accessed 7 December 2025).
- Dáil Éireann (July 6, 1982). *D'ail debates: 6 July 1982, item 38*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.oireachtas.ie/ga/debates/debate/dail/1982-07-06/38/> (accessed 8 November 2025).
- (July 14, 2021). *Dáil debates: 14 July 2021: State Bodies*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.oireachtas.ie/en/debates/question/2021-07-14/21/> (accessed 11 November 2025).

Reference List

- Dáil Éireann (March 29, 2022). *An Garda Síochána: written answer, Question 127, 29 March 2022*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.oireachtas.ie/en/debates/question/2022-03-29/127/#pq-answers-127> (accessed 8 November 2025).
- Defence Forces Officer (October 8, 2025). *Email to the author*.
- Department of Defence (October 23, 2025). *Department of Defence - who does what*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.gov.ie/en/department-of-defence/organisation-information/department-of-defence-who-does-what/> (accessed 2 December 2025).
- Department of Defence and Defence Forces (2024). *Defence policy review 2024: adjusting and affirming our defence policy in an era of change*. Newbridge: Department of Defence and Defence Forces.
- Department of Public Expenditure and Reform (April 2022). *Organisational capability review: Department of Defence*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://assets.gov.ie/static/documents/organisational-capability-review-78c44f6d-24f7-4500-a2ad-179a04179ac5.pdf> (accessed 2 December 2025).
- (2023). *Statement of strategy 2023–25*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://assets.gov.ie/static/documents/statement-of-strategy-2023-2025-1be36fdf-e56a-4c9f-91dc-e911c78b6680.pdf> (accessed 2 December 2025).
- Department of the Taoiseach (December 5, 2019). *Public consultation on the development of a national security strategy*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.gov.ie/en/department-of-the-taoiseach/consultations/public-consultation-on-the-development-of-a-national-security-strategy-2/>.
- Dixon, W. and Beznosiuk, M. (December 19, 2022). *Russia is losing — time for Putin's 2026 hybrid escalation*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.rusi.org/explore-our-research/publications/commentary/russia->

losing-time-putins-2026-hybrid-escalation (accessed 20 December 2025).

Dobias, P. and Christensen, K. (2022). The ‘Grey Zone’ and Hybrid Activities. *Connections: The Quarterly Journal*, 21 (2), pp. 41–54. DOI: 10.11610/Connections.21.2.03. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://doi.org/10.11610/Connections.21.2.03>.

Donegal Live (August 20, 2021). *Defence Forces monitoring Russian spy ship spotted off Donegal coast*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.donegallive.ie/news/local-news/658032/defence-forces-monitoring-russian-spy-ship-spotted-off-donegal-coast.html> (accessed 29 November 2025).

Dunphy, L. (December 5, 2025). *Retiring Irish navy chief warns of Cold War-level global threat*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.irishexaminer.com/news/spotlight/arid-41755323.html> (accessed 7 December 2025).

Eken, M. et al. (2025). *Understanding Russian strategic culture and the low-yield nuclear threat*. Cambridge and Santa Monica: RAND Europe.

European Commission (March 19, 2025). *White paper for European defence: readiness 2030*. Brussels: European Commission. [online]. Available at: URL: https://commission.europa.eu/document/download/e6d5db69-e0ab-4bec-9dc0-3867b4373019_en.

European Defence Agency (February 20, 2020). *Underwater control contributing to resilience at sea*. Brussels: European Defence Agency.

European Parliament (October 8, 2025). *European Parliament plenary debate, 8 October 2025*. [online]. Available at: URL: https://www.europarl.europa.eu/doceo/document/CRE-10-2025-10-08-ITM-003_EN.html (accessed 3 December 2025).

European Union (March 2, 2013). *Protocol on the concerns of the Irish people on the Treaty of Lisbon*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://eur-lex.europa.eu/>

Reference List

- legal-content/EN/TXT/HTML/?uri=CELEX%3A22013A0302%2801%29 (accessed 3 December 2025).
- European Union (March 2023). *EU maritime security strategy: security compass*. Brussels: European Union.
- Europol (2025). *Serious and organised crime threat assessment (SOCTA) 2025. Part 1: the changing DNA of serious and organised crime*. [online]. Available at: URL: https://fiaumalta.org/app/uploads/2025/03/Mar-2025-Serious-and-Organised-Crime-Threat-Assessment-SOCTA-2025_Part1.pdf (accessed 3 December 2025).
- Fanning, R. (2015). *Éamon de Valera: A will to power*. London: Faber & Faber.
- Fitzgerald, E. (2025). *Cognitive overload: The hidden killer in combat systems*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.getambush.com/article/cognitive-load-optimization-in-combat-systems/> (accessed 17 December 2025).
- Fox, J. (July 24, 2025a). *Data flags hundreds of Russian 'shadow fleet' visits to Irish EEZ*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.rte.ie/news/primetime/2025/0724/1525050-shadow-fleet-irish-eez/> (accessed 30 November 2025).
- (April 11, 2025b). *Russian intelligence ship monitored off Irish coast*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.rte.ie/news/ireland/2025/0410/1506999-russian-intelligence-ship-irish-waters/> (accessed 29 November 2025).
- Fox, J. and Mcdonald, K. (July 3, 2025). *Defence Forces monitor Russian vessel off Irish coast*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.rte.ie/news/ireland/2025/0703/1521670-russian-vessel-ireland/> (accessed 29 November 2025).
- Franceinfo avec AFP (December 5, 2025). *La marine nationale a tiré hier sur des drones au-dessus de la base de l'île Longue, qui abrite les sous-marins nucléaires français dans le Finistère*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.franceinfo.fr/>

economie/emploi/metiers/armee-et-securite/la-base-sous-marine-de-l-ile-longue-dans-le-finistere-qui-abrite-les-sous-marins-nucleaires-francais-a-ete-survolee-par-des-drones_7659868.html (accessed 5 December 2025).

Friedner Parrat, C. (2024). Change in international order? An institutional analysis. *European Journal of International Security*, 9 (3), pp. 449–467. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://doi.org/10.1017/eis.2024.13> (accessed 4 October 2025).

Gallagher, C. (August 30, 2022). *Defence Forces monitoring Russian warships acting unusually off Irish south coast*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.irishtimes.com/ireland/2022/08/30/defence-forces-monitoring-russian-warships-acting-unusually-off-irish-south-coast/> (accessed 29 November 2025).

— (May 8, 2023). *Secret Anglo-Irish air defence agreement dates back over 70 years*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.irishtimes.com/ireland/2023/05/08/secret-anglo-irish-air-defence-agreement-dates-back-over-70-years/> (accessed 30 November 2025).

— (June 6, 2024). *‘Eye of the State’: on patrol with the Irish Air Corps’ new maritime aircraft*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.irishtimes.com/ireland/2024/06/05/eye-of-the-state-on-patrol-with-the-irish-air-corps-new-maritime-aircraft/> (accessed 28 November 2025).

— (November 20, 2025a). *Helen McEntee briefed on Russian spy ship movements by military chief*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.irishtimes.com/ireland/2025/11/20/defence-forces-may-deploy-ship-to-monitor-russian-vessel-in-irish-waters/> (accessed 29 November 2025).

— (August 30, 2025b). *Ireland must focus more on fending off external threats, Defence Forces chief says*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.irishtimes.com/ireland/2025/08/30/ireland-must-focus-more-on->

Reference List

- fending-off-external-threats-defence-forces-chief-says/
(accessed 30 November 2025).
- Gallagher, C. (January 14, 2025c). *Irish military aircraft deployed to monitor Russian 'shadow fleet' vessel*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.irishtimes.com/ireland/2025/01/14/irish-military-aircraft-deployed-to-monitor-russian-shadow-fleet-vessel/> (accessed 30 November 2025).
- (August 30, 2025d). *New Defence Forces chief: 'Ireland has to be able to provide a defence to repel any initial invasion'*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.irishtimes.com/ireland/2025/08/30/new-defence-forces-chief-prioritises-becoming-equipped-to-repel-hostile-forces/> (accessed 30 November 2025).
- (March 3, 2025e). No strategy, ad hoc structures, mutual distrust: welcome to Ireland's intelligence service. The Irish Times. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.irishtimes.com/ireland/2025/03/03/no-strategy-ad-hoc-structures-mutual-distrust-welcome-to-irelands-intelligence-service/> (accessed 8 November 2025).
- George, A. L. and Bennett, A. (2005). *Case studies and theory development in the social sciences*. Cambridge, MA: The MIT Press. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://mitpress.mit.edu/9780262572224/case-studies-and-theory-development-in-the-social-sciences/> (accessed 29 October 2025).
- Gerasimov, V. (February 2013). The Value of Science is in the Foresight. Military-Industrial Kurier (8/27).
- Government of Ireland (April 21, 1924). *Ministers and Secretaries Act 1924*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://revisedacts.lawreform.ie/eli/1924/act/16/revised/en/pdf?annotations=true> (accessed 10 November 2025).

- (1937). *Bunreacht na hÉireann: Constitution of Ireland*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.irishstatutebook.ie/pdf/en.cons.pdf> (accessed 10 November 2025).
- (May 13, 1954). *Defence Act 1954*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.irishstatutebook.ie/eli/1954/act/18/enacted/en/html> (accessed 8 November 2025).
- (2004). *Maritime Security Act 2004*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.irishstatutebook.ie/eli/2004/act/29/enacted/en/pdf> (accessed 17 November 2025).
- (2022). *High-Level Action Plan on the report of the Commission on the Defence Forces*:
Government Offices of Sweden (July 8, 2024). *National security strategy*. Stockholm: Government Offices of Sweden. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.government.se/information-material/2024/07/national-security-strategy/>.
- Gray, C. (2011). *War, peace and international relations: an introduction to strategic history*. London: Routledge.
- Gunneriusson, H. (2019). Hybrid warfare and deniability as understood by the military. *Polish Political Science Yearbook*, 48 (2), pp. 267–288. DOI: 10.15804/ppsy2019205. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.czasopisma.marszalek.com.pl/images/pliki/ppsy/48-2/ppsy2019205.pdf> (accessed 28 November 2025).
- Harris, S. (November 6, 2025a). *Defence Forces: radar and surveillance capabilities*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.oireachtas.ie/en/debates/debate/dail/2025-11-06/2/> (accessed 2 December 2025).
- (June 12, 2025b). *Naval Service: parliamentary question no. 6, 12 June 2025*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.oireachtas.ie/en/debates/question/2025-06-12/6/> (accessed 3 December 2025).

Reference List

- HM Government (June 24, 2025). *National security strategy 2025: security for the British people in a dangerous world*. London: Cabinet Office. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/national-security-strategy-2025-security-for-the-british-people-in-a-dangerous-world>.
- Hoffman, F. G. (December 2007). *Conflict in the 21st Century: The Rise of Hybrid Wars*. Arlington, VA: Potomac Institute for Policy Studies. [online]. Available at: URL: <http://www.potomac institute.org>.
- Hoffman, F. G., Neumeyer, M., and Jensen, B. (July 8, 2024). *The Future of Hybrid Warfare*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.csis.org/analysis/future-hybrid-warfare> (accessed 20 November 2025).
- House of Commons (November 7, 2022). *House of Commons parliamentary debates (Hansard), 7 November 2022*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://hansard.parliament.uk/pdf/commons/2022-11-07> (accessed 30 November 2025).
- Houses of the Oireachtas (February 20, 1991). *Dáil Éireann debate, 20 February 1991*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.oireachtas.ie/en/debates/debate/dail/1991-02-20/18/> (accessed 30 November 2025).
- (November 16, 2005). *Dáil Éireann debate, 16 November 2005*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.oireachtas.ie/en/debates/debate/dail/2005-11-16/3/> (accessed 30 November 2025).
- (November 24, 2015). *Dáil Éireann debate, priority questions, 24 November 2015*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.oireachtas.ie/en/debates/debate/dail/2015-11-24/3/> (accessed 28 November 2025).
- (April 12, 2017). *Dáil Éireann debate, 12 April 2017*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.oireachtas.ie/en/debates/debate/dail/2017-04-12/20/> (accessed 30 November 2025).

- (April 22, 2021). *Dáil Éireann debate, 22 April 2021*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.oireachtas.ie/en/debates/debate/dail/2021-04-22/8/> (accessed 3 December 2025).
- (July 12, 2022). *Joint Committee on Foreign Affairs and Defence debate, 12 July 2022*. [online]. Available at: URL: https://data.oireachtas.ie/ie/oireachtas/debateRecord/joint_committee_on_foreign_affairs_and_defence/2022-07-12/debate/mul@/main.pdf (accessed 30 November 2025).
- (May 18, 2023). *Dáil Éireann debate, 18 May 2023*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.oireachtas.ie/en/debates/debate/dail/2023-05-18/32/> (accessed 30 November 2025).
- (May 15, 2024). *Joint committee on European Union affairs debate, 15 May 2024*. [online]. Available at: URL: https://www.oireachtas.ie/en/debates/debate/joint_committee_on_european_union_affairs/2024-05-15/2/ (accessed 30 November 2025).
- (April 1, 2025a). *Dáil Éireann debate, 1 April 2025*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.oireachtas.ie/en/debates/debate/dail/2025-04-01/10/> (accessed 4 December 2025).
- (October 2, 2025b). *Debate, Joint Committee on Defence and National Security, 2 October 2025*. [online]. Available at: URL: https://www.oireachtas.ie/en/debates/debate/joint_committee_on_defence_and_national_security/2025-10-02/3/ (accessed 29 November 2025).
- (April 1, 2025c). *Military neutrality: written answers, parliamentary question no. 137, 1 April 2025*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.oireachtas.ie/en/debates/question/2025-04-01/137/> (accessed 3 December 2025).
- (February 13, 2025d). *Seanad Éireann debate, 13 February 2025*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.oireachtas.ie/en/debates/debate/seanad/2025-02-13/5/> (accessed 30 November 2025).

Reference List

- Huntington, S. P. (1957). *The Soldier and the State: The Theory and Politics of Civil–Military Relations*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://doi.org/10.2307/j.ctvjf9wx3> (accessed 12 October 2025).
- Hussey, S. (April 11, 2025). *Russian ship leaves Irish waters after Defence Forces monitoring operation*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.rte.ie/news/ireland/2025/0411/1507155-russian-ship/> (accessed 29 November 2025).
- Hynes, G. (2024). Neutral, neutered or pacifist? Can Ireland’s model of neutrality remain aligned With its foreign policy ambitions amidst the re-emergence of conflict in Europe. *Journal Of Military History and Defence Studies*, 5 (1), pp. 164–199. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://doi.org/10.33232/JMHDS.5.1.95> (accessed 26 November 2025).
- Ince, M. (December 11, 2025). *Maintaining the UK’s intelligence edge in the grey zone*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.rusi.org/explore-our-research/publications/commentary/maintaining-uks-intelligence-edge-grey-zone> (accessed 12 December 2025).
- International Maritime Organization (n.d.). *United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS)*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.imo.org/en/ourwork/legal/pages/unitednationsconventiononthelawofthesea.aspx> (accessed 28 November 2025).
- Janowitz, M. (1960). *The professional soldier: a social and political portrait*. New York: Free Press, Simon & Schuster. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.simonandschuster.com/books/The-Professional-Soldier/Morris-Janowitz/9781501179327> (accessed 12 October 2025).
- Jones, S. G. (March 18, 2025). *Russia’s shadow war against the West*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.csis.org/analysis/russias-shadow-war-against-west> (accessed 4 December 2025).

- King, J. (December 1, 2025). *Damning critique of Ireland's shambolic defences stings because it rings true*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.businesspost.ie/analysis-opinion/jackie-king-damning-critique-of-irelands-shambolic-defences-stings-because-it-rings-true/> (accessed 3 December 2025).
- Lally, C., Gallagher, C., and Paul, M. (December 6, 2025). *Senior gardaí query 'weak' response from Defence Forces to rogue drones during Zelenskiy visit*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.irishtimes.com/ireland/2025/12/06/senior-gardai-query-weak-response-from-defence-forces-to-rogue-drones-during-zelenskiy-visit/> (accessed 6 December 2025).
- Larsson, O. L. (2024). Sea blindness in grey zone preparations. *Defence Studies*, 24 (3), pp. 399–420. DOI: 10.1080/14702436.2024.2359913. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://doi.org/10.1080/14702436.2024.2359913>.
- Leahy, P. and Gallagher, C. (March 4, 2022). *Irish neutrality means whatever the government of the day wants it to mean*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.irishtimes.com/news/politics/irish-neutrality-means-whatever-the-government-of-the-day-wants-it-to-mean-1.4818543> (accessed 7 December 2025).
- Lemmon, J. (2024). The weaponization of fiction and truth: disinformation as hybrid warfare and its strategic use in the United States 2024 election. *National Security and the Future*, 25 (2), pp. 132–176. DOI: 10.37458/nstf.25.2.5. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://doi.org/10.37458/nstf.25.2.5> (accessed 28 November 2025).
- Linklater, A. and Suganami, H. (2006). *The English School of international relations: a contemporary reassessment*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://doi.org/10.1017/CBO9780511491524> (accessed 15 October 2025).

Reference List

- Mattis, J. N. and Hoffman, F. G. (November 2005). Future warfare: the rise of hybrid wars. *Proceedings*, 131 (11), pp. 18–19.
- McCabe, R. and Flynn, B. (2024). *Under the radar: Ireland, maritime security capacity, and the governance of subsea infrastructure*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://doi.org/10.1080/09662839.2023.2248001> (accessed 5 November 2025).
- McDonnell, N. (December 13, 2025). *After the Zelenskyy visit*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.linkedin.com/pulse/after-zelenskyy-visit-neil-mcdonnell-x4exf/> (accessed 14 December 2025).
- Mearsheimer, J. J. (1990). Back to the future: instability in Europe after the Cold War. *International Security*, 15 (1), pp. 5–56. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.jstor.org/stable/2538981> (accessed 29 November 2025).
- (1994). The false promise of international institutions. *International Security*, 19 (3), pp. 5–49.
- (2001). *The tragedy of great power politics*: W. W. Norton & Company.
- (2014). Why the Ukraine crisis is the West’s fault: the liberal delusions that provoked Putin. *Foreign Affairs*, 93 (5), pp. 77–89.
- Meenan, C. (March 18, 2025). *Gerard Craughwell v Government of Ireland, Ireland and the Attorney General*. [online]. Available at: URL: https://ww2.courts.ie/acc/alfresco/c8306ffe-9d9e-477f-98f4-831ea939184d/2025_IECA_63.pdf/pdf#view=fith (accessed 30 November 2025).
- Mooney, J. (May 14, 2023). *Why are Russian spy ships free to prowl Irish waters*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.thetimes.com/world/ireland-world/article/why-are-russian-spy-ships-free-to-prowl-irish-waters-zx0krnn6c> (accessed 29 November 2025).
- (June 2, 2024). *Britain, France and Norway search for Russian sub off Ireland*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.thetimes.com/world/ireland-world/article/britain-france-and-norway-search-for-russian-sub-off-ireland-cwljngdsj> (accessed 28 November 2025).

- Mulcahy, R. (November 15, 2025). Chief of Staff's notes to the Defence Board on the shadow fleet.
- Murphy, C. (June 11, 2025). *Ireland, the triple lock and military neutrality*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.iiia.com/publications/ireland-the-triple-lock-and-military-neutrality> (accessed 5 December 2025).
- EU-NATO Task Force on the Resilience of Critical Infrastructure (June 2023). *EU-NATO task force on the resilience of critical infrastructure: final assessment report*. Brussels: European Union and North Atlantic Treaty Organisation.
- New Zealand Security Intelligence Service (2025). *New Zealand's security threat environment 2025: an assessment by the New Zealand Security Intelligence Service*. Wellington: New Zealand Security Intelligence Service. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.nzsis.govt.nz/assets/NZSIS-Documents/New-Zealands-Security-Threat-Environment-2025.pdf>.
- North Atlantic Treaty Organization (May 7, 2024). *Countering hybrid threats*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.nato.int/en/what-we-do/deterrence-and-defence/countering-hybrid-threats> (accessed 4 December 2025).
- O'Connell, H. and Collins, S. (January 30, 2024). *'We broke up years ago': Clare Daly on Latvian MEP being probed over Russian spy claims*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.independent.ie/irish-news/politics/we-broke-up-years-ago-clare-daly-on-latvian-mep-being-probed-over-russian-spy-claims/a881263189.html> (accessed 29 November 2025).
- O'Connor, N. (December 6, 2025a). *Irish naval ship monitored suspicious vessel off Dublin during Zelenskyy visit*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.thejournal.ie/latest-on-suspicious-drone-activity-in-irish-sea-6895675-Dec2025/> (accessed 7 December 2025).
- (December 9, 2025b). *Portuguese, French and PSNI anti-drone police units deployed in Dublin during Zelenskyy visit*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.>

Reference List

- thejournal.ie/foreign-police-in-dublin-for-counter-drone-tech-during-zelenskyy-visit-6898302-Dec2025/?utm_source=shortlink (accessed 9 December 2025).
- O'Connor, R. (December 9, 2025). *Irish Air Component*. Lecture. JCSC lecture hall.
- O'Keeffe, C. (December 20, 2025a). 'Russia was behind drone incursion during Zelenskyy visit' say Irish security sources. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.irishtimes.com/news/arid-41763413.html> (accessed 20 December 2025).
- (March 21, 2025b). *Navy monitoring suspected Russian 'shadow fleet' tanker near Foynes port*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.irishtimes.com/news/munster/arid-41597923.html> (accessed 29 November 2025).
- O'Leary, N. (January 29, 2024a). *Latvian MEP linked to Wallace and Daly accused of working with Russian intelligence*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.irishtimes.com/politics/2024/01/29/latvian-mep-linked-to-wallace-and-daly-accused-of-working-with-russian-intelligence/> (accessed 29 November 2025).
- (February 11, 2024b). *Wallace and Daly issue legal letter over Fine Gael statement about links to alleged Russian informant*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.irishtimes.com/politics/2024/02/11/wallace-and-daly-issue-legal-letter-over-fine-gael-statement-about-links-to-alleged-russian-informant/> (accessed 29 November 2025).
- Office of the Director of National Intelligence (March 2025). *Annual threat assessment of the U.S. intelligence community*. Washington, DC: Office of the Director of National Intelligence. [online]. Available at: URL: /mnt/data/US_National_Threat_Assessment.pdf.
- Óglaigh na hÉireann (2022). *Irish Defence Forces monitor international warships*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.flickr.com/photos/dfmagazine/albums/72177720296449558/with/51862024064> (accessed 29 November 2025).

- (April 1, 2023). *Irish Defence Forces monitor Russian commercial ships off west coast*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.military.ie/en/news-and-events/news/irish-defence-forces-monitor-russian-commercial-ships-off-west-coast.html> (accessed 29 November 2025).
- (November 25, 2025). *Information knowledge online*.
- Pogatchnik, S. (October 7, 2024). *Russia recruited an Irish agent to exploit Brexit tensions. He's still sitting in Ireland's parliament*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.politico.eu/article/russia-intelligence-kremlin-irish-lawmakers-propaganda-news/> (accessed 29 November 2025).
- Putin, V. V. (February 10, 2007). *Speech and the following discussion at the Munich conference on security policy*. [online]. Available at: URL: <http://en.kremlin.ru/events/president/transcripts/24034> (accessed 29 November 2025).
- (February 24, 2022). *Address by the President of the Russian Federation*. [online]. Available at: URL: <http://en.kremlin.ru/events/president/transcripts/67843> (accessed 29 November 2025).
- (February 6, 2024). *The Vladimir Putin interview*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://tuckercarlson.com/the-vladimir-putin-interview> (accessed 29 November 2025).
- Regan, M. and Sari, A. (2024). *Hybrid threats and grey zone conflict: the challenge to liberal democracies*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Robinson, N. (October 7, 2025). *Russia, threat and perceptions*.
- Sanaei, M. (2024). The transition of international order: current debates and future directions. *China Quarterly of International Strategic Studies*, 10 (02), pp. 133–153. DOI: 10.1142/S2377740024500064. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.worldscientific.com/doi/10.1142/S2377740024500064> (accessed 4 October 2025).

Reference List

- Sari, A. (March 2025). *Protecting maritime infrastructure from hybrid threats: legal options*. Helsinki: European Centre of Excellence for Countering Hybrid Threats. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.hybridcoe.fi>.
- Senior Irish Army Officer (November 20, 2025). *Personal communication regarding Irish defence and security issues*.
- Stensrud, C. J. and Østhagen, A. (2024). Hybrid Warfare at sea? Russia, Svalbard and the Arctic. *Scandinavian Journal of Military Studies*, 7 (1), pp. 111–130. DOI: 10.31374/sjms.233. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://doi.org/10.31374/sjms.233>.
- The Irish Insider (July 24, 2025). *Russian ships in Irish waters threaten national security*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://theirishinsider.ie/the-local-lens/latest-updates/russian-ships-in-irish-waters/> (accessed 29 November 2025).
- The Irish Politics Newsletter (December 5, 2025). *Ireland - the cosseted child of Europe*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.irishpoliticsnewsletter.ie/p/ireland-neutrality> (accessed 5 December 2025).
- The Sunday Times Ireland (December 6, 2025a). *Ireland security inquiry into Russian 'drone raid' on Zelensky jet*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.thetimes.com/world/ireland-world/article/ireland-security-inquiry-into-russian-drone-raid-on-zelensky-jet-qvv5r73vn> (accessed 7 December 2025).
- (December 6, 2025b). *Irish Defence Forces chief: Russian war has changed everything*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.thetimes.com/world/ireland-world/article/irish-defence-forces-mulcahy-security-threat-5mwx50qvk> (accessed 7 December 2025).
- UK Ministry of Defence (November 19, 2025). *Post on Russian spy ship Yantar near UK waters*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://x.com/DefenceHQ/status/1991101254857064568>.

- United Nations (December 10, 1982). *United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea*. [online]. Available at: URL: https://www.un.org/depts/los/convention_agreements/texts/unclos/unclos_e.pdf (accessed 28 November 2025).
- (n.d.). *Declarations and statements upon ratification, acceptance, approval or accession to the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea*. [online]. Available at: URL: https://www.un.org/Depts/los/convention_agreements/convention_declarations.htm (accessed 28 November 2025).
- Varadkar, L. (December 13, 2025). *Being neutral means staying out of Nato, not being weak*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.thetimes.com/article/4a71e93a-e0bb-4abc-9b27-a81b12c6855e?shareToken=ed71ac50c7510f594524dc75a3a2d7de> (accessed 14 December 2025).
- Webber, J. and Warrell, H. (November 25, 2025). How Ireland became the weak spot in Europe's defences. Financial Times. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.ft.com/content/4748d385-877b-40f3-a1ca-0b8ed5177658> (accessed 25 November 2025).
- Wilson, T. (December 12, 2025). *MoD to unify all intelligence units under single command*. [online]. Available at: URL: <https://www.bbc.com/news/articles/cd6xx0w8jx5o> (accessed 12 December 2025).

Glossary of Terms

Department of Defence Government of Ireland (1924, sec. 1(x)) states that, “ The Department of Defence which shall comprise the administration and business of the raising, training, organisation, maintenance, equipment, management, discipline, regulation, and control according to law of the Military Defence Forces of Saorstát Eireann, and all powers, duties and functions connected with the same, and of which Department the head shall be, and shall be styled, an t-Aire Cosanta or (in English) the Minister for Defence”. Government of Ireland (1954, sec. F20) states that, “There shall stand established in the Department of Defence a military element (which shall be known, and is referred to in this Act, as ”Defence Forces Headquarters”), the head of which shall be the Chief of Staff.” Colloquially however, DFHQ is often referred to as part of and representing the Defence Forces. Hence, for the purposes of this essay, DOD and DFHQ shall be treated separately.

Exclusive Economic Zone The exclusive economic zone is an area beyond and adjacent to the territorial sea. The exclusive economic zone shall not extend beyond 200 nautical miles from the baselines from which the breadth of the territorial sea is measured. (United Nations 1982, pp. 43–44).

Free-riding “States benefit from a good provided collectively by a group of states but only contribute in a limited way, if at all, to the costs of providing that collective good”, (Cottey 2022, p. 6).

Grey Zone For this essay, the grey zone denotes the international-security space between routine peace and declared war. Therein actors use coercive, often deniable tools below the threshold of open armed conflict. The idea overlaps with, but is broader than, Hoffman’s notion of “hybrid warfare” (Mattis and Hoffman 2005). Russia’s annexation of Crimea, achieved through covert forces and information operations before large-scale fighting, illustrates grey zone activity that still caused

deaths and territorial change. By contrast, the use of drones to disrupt President Zelenskyy's arrival at Dublin Airport (1/12/25) would sit at the non-lethal, disruptive end of the same spectrum. Both examples fall within the grey zone, but only the former approaches hybrid warfare.

Hybrid Attack This is a limited, plausibly deniable use of force or disruption intended less to achieve decisive military effect than to send a political message: it exploits ambiguity so that overt retaliation appears pre-emptive and disproportionate, while non-response risks a slow 'death by a thousand cuts' (Dobias and Christensen 2022; Jones 2025; EU-NATO Task Force on the Resilience of Critical Infrastructure 2023; North Atlantic Treaty Organization 2024).

Main Directorate for Deep Sea Research GUGI, a clandestine arm of Russia's defence ministry, operates specialised submarines and surface vessels for seabed operations, including tapping or damaging undersea fibre-optic cables (Jones 2025). Some sixteen commercially operated cables carry the vast majority of transatlantic data traffic and are physically fragile, so even deliberate or accidental anchor dragging can disrupt them without recourse to exotic military tools.

Neutrality (Irish) "Ireland's policy of military neutrality does not align with accepted concepts of neutrality reflected in literature on the topic. The paper finds Irish Neutrality is better described as military non-alignment which is labelled "neutrality", (Hynes 2024, p. 164).

Normative (English School use) In this context, 'normative' means giving prescriptive guidance for how states *ought* to act to uphold and improve the moral quality of international life. It is grounded in real trends and practical steps, not abstract theory alone (Linklater and Suganami 2006, pp. 9–11).

Strategic Deterrence "Russian euphemism for nuclear and non-nuclear coercion (both deterrence and compellence) across all domains" (Adamsky 2025, p. 50).

Territorial sea The sovereignty of a coastal State extends, beyond its land territory and internal waters and, in the case of an archipelagic State, its archipelagic waters, to an adjacent belt of sea, described as the territorial sea. This sovereignty extends to the air space over the territorial sea as well as to its bed and subsoil. Every State has the right to establish the breadth of its territorial sea up to a limit not exceeding 12 nautical miles, measured from baselines determined in accordance with this Convention. (United Nations 1982, p. 27).

United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea “Was adopted in 1982 and entered into force in 1994. It lays down a comprehensive regime of law and order for the world’s oceans, establishing rules for the allocation of States’ rights and jurisdiction in maritime spaces, the peaceful use of the oceans, and the management of their resources. The Convention also provides a framework for the further development of specific areas of the law of the sea, including through the work of competent international organizations such as the IMO” (International Maritime Organization n.d.). It has been ratified by Ireland (United Nations n.d.). Per United Nations (1982), of particular note are Articles: 1–3 (definition and breadth of the territorial sea); 17–19 (right and meaning of innocent passage within territorial waters); 55–57 (definition and breadth of the EEZ); 73 (enforcement of living resources laws within EEZ); 76 (definition and breadth of the continental shelf); 79 (submarine cables and pipelines); 90–91 (right of navigation on the high seas and nationality of ships); 95–96 (immunity of warships and government ships on the high seas); 110–111 (right of visit and hot-pursuit); 113–114 (breaking or injury of a submarine cable or pipeline).

List of Acronyms

AGS An Garda Síochána.

C-UAS Counter Uncrewed Aerial System.

CI Chief Instructor.

CISE Common Information Sharing Environment.

COD-6 Current Operations Document 6.

CODF Commission on the Defence Forces.

COS Chief of Staff.

CSDP Common Security and Defence Policy.

DF Defence Forces.

DPER Department of Public Expenditure and Reform.

EDA European Defence Agency.

EEZ Exclusive Economic Zone.

EU European Union.

GBAD Ground Based Air Defence.

GFA Good Friday Agreement.

GWOT Global War on Terror.

IMIS Irish Military Intelligence Service.

IR International Relations.

List of Acronyms

ISR Intelligence Surveillance and Reconnaissance.

ITPP Individual Tailored Partnership Programme.

JEF Joint Expeditionary Force.

LIO Liberal International Order.

LOA Level of Ambition.

MALE Medium Altitude Long Endurance.

MARSUR EDA Project: Maritime Surveillance.

MDA Maritime Domain Awareness.

MEP Member of the European Parliament.

MSS Maritime Security Strategy.

NATO North Atlantic Treaty Organisation.

NCSIS National Crime and Security Intelligence Service.

NSA National Security Agency.

NSAC National Security Assessment Centre.

NSC National Security Council.

NSS National Security Strategy.

NSSt National Security Secretariat.

OCR Operational Capability Review.

OPV Offshore Patrol Vessel.

PCN Picture Control Network.

RAF Royal Air Force.

RAP Recognised Air Picture.

RMP Recognised Maritime Picture.

RSF Russian Shadow Fleet.

TEU Treaty of the European Union.

UAS Uncrewed Aerial System.

UNCLOS United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea.

Index

- Ahern, Bertie, 28
- Air Corps, *see* Defence Forces
- Air Interdiction, 14
- An Garda Síochána, 30
 - State security agency, 7
- Austria, 13
- Bunreacht na hÉireann, 3, 24
 - Article 29.5.1, 9
- Buoy, 6
- Common Defence, *see* EU
- Craughwell, Gerard, 28
 - Constitutional challenge, 9
- Crime, 2
 - Russian criminal proxies, 14
 - Troubles frames as criminality, 7
- Critical Infrastructure, 18
- de Valera, Éamon, 14, 25
 - Neutrality as a pragmatic hedge, 11
- Defence Forces, 30
 - Air Corps, 11
 - C295 Maritime Patrol Aircraft, 11
 - Critical infrastructure partnerships, 13
- Deniability, 7
- Disinformation, 7
- Dublin airport drone incident, 18, 20
- Estonia, 29
- EU
 - Article 42.7 — mutual assistance, 4, 6, 18, 24
- Extremism, 2
- Finland, 29
- France, 29
- Gerasimov, Valery, 7
- Grey Zone
 - Deniability, 7
 - Disinformation, 7
 - Russian below-threshold operations, 7
 - Russian strategic deterrence narrative, 3
 - Weakness of, 14
- Haughey, Seán, 14, 28
- Heappey, James, 14, 28
- Hot Pursuit, 8
- Iceland
 - Critical submarine infrastructure seminar, 13
- ITPP

- Ireland, 29
- MARA, *see* Maritime Area Regulatory Authority
 - Authority
- Maritime Area Regulatory Authority, 9
- Maritime Security Strategy, 20, 30
- Mearsheimer, John, 2
- MSS, *see* Maritime Security Strategy
- Munich speech, *see* Putin, Vladimir
- National Security Agency, 6, 30
- NATO
 - Article 5, 6, 21, 24
 - Critical infrastructure partnerships, 13
 - Irish response is consistent with, 11
- Naval Service, *see* Defence Forces 12, 30
- Netherlands, 29
- Norway, 29
- NSAC, 30
- Performative Neutrality, 5, 9, 14, 19, 20, 22
- Procurement
 - Has not matched political ambition, 7
- Putin, Vladimir
 - Hypocrisy, 2
 - Munich speech, 2
- Radar
 - Land-based high-frequency, 6
- RAF, 14, *see* Royal Air Force
- Realism
 - Contemporary Ireland, 14
 - de Valera, 14
 - Offensive realism, 2
- Royal Air Force, 14
 - Alleged secret air-interdiction deal, 9, 28
- Russia
 - Deniability and Disinformation, 7
 - Disinformation, 7
 - Grey Zone
 - Weakness of, 14
- Secret (RAF) deal, 9, 28
- Soft underbelly of Europe, 2, 7, 16
- Sunk cost, 6
- Svalbard archipelago, 12
- Switzerland, 13
- Taoiseach, 28
- Terrorism, 2
- Troubles, 7
- UK, 29
 - Public reporting of incidents, 7
- UNCLOS
 - Hot pursuit, 8
- von der Leyen, Ursula
 - Russian hybrid actions in Europe, 8
- Wilson, John P., 28